Cold DM and Email Templates

to reach startup founders and get hired

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Why this works

- I sent 200+ job applications. Almost nothing came back.
- Then I started messaging founders directly on LinkedIn. About 30% replied.
- Founder interviews skip DSA and system design. They talk about their real project and the problem they are stuck on.
- Usually it is one technical round, then a round with the founder, then the offer. I got 3-4 offers this way.

Hard truth: cold DMs have low odds. Most people will not reply. So send many, keep each one short, and make each one personal.

How to use these

- Copy a template. Replace everything in **[orange brackets]**. Delete the brackets.
- Keep it under 80 words. Founders read on their phone.
- Always add one project with a link. One real project beats a list of skills.
- Say how you can help them, not only what you want.
- Make the first line personal: their funding, launch, post or product.
- Follow up once after 3-4 days. Then move on.

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2. LinkedIn DM for a referral (employee or hiring manager)
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1. LinkedIn DM to a founder

Use when: a startup just raised money, launched something, or posted about hiring.

Hi **[Name]**,

Congrats on **[funding / launch / recent post]**. Really liked what **[Company]** is doing with **[their product or problem]**.

I'm a **[your role]** with **[X]** years of experience in **[skill 1]**, **[skill 2]** and **[skill 3]**. **[Degree, College]** (optional).

Recently I built **[project name]**: **[what it does in one line]**, **[result or number]**. Link: **[GitHub / demo link]**

I think I can help **[Company]** with **[one specific thing you can build or fix]**.

Open to a quick chat? Happy to share my resume.

Thanks,
[Your Name]

2. LinkedIn DM for a referral

Use when: you found an open role and want a referral from someone working there.

Hi **[Name]**,

Saw the **[Role]** opening at **[Company]** (**[Location]**, Job ID: **[ID]**). It looks like a great fit for my profile.

I'm a **[your role]** with **[X]** years in **[skill 1]**, **[skill 2]** and **[skill 3]**. **[Degree, College]** (optional).

Recently built **[project name]**: **[one line + result]**. Link: **[GitHub / demo link]**

If you're open to it, a referral would mean a lot. I can send my resume anytime.

Thanks a lot!
[Your Name]

3. Cold email to a founder

Use when: you can find the founder's email (company website, LinkedIn, Twitter / X).

Subject: **[Your role]** who can help with **[their product area]**

Hi **[Name]**,

I've been following **[Company]** and what you're building with **[product]**. **[One honest line on why it caught your eye]**.

I'm a **[your role]** with **[X]** years of experience in **[skill 1]**, **[skill 2]** and **[skill 3]**.

One project close to what you're building:
[Project name]: **[what it does]**, **[result or number]**. Link: **[GitHub / demo link]**

An idea for **[Company]**: **[one line on how you would improve or build something for them]**.

Open to a 15 minute call this week? My resume is attached.

Best,
[Your Name]
[LinkedIn link] | **[Portfolio / GitHub link]**

4. Follow-up (after 3-4 days, only once)

Hi **[Name]**, just following up on my last message.

I'd love to help with **[specific thing]**. Here's my **[project name]** in case it's useful: **[link]**.

Thanks!

5. How to crack the founder interview

- Before the call, use their product. Read their website, posts and job description.
- Guess the problem they are stuck on right now. Think how you would solve it.
- In the call they will talk about their current project. No DSA, no system design.
- Give a relevant solution and a clear path: "We can solve this in these 3 steps."
- Talk about your own project the same way: problem, what you built, result.
- If they are convinced, the next round is with the founder. Then the offer.

Quick checklist before you hit send

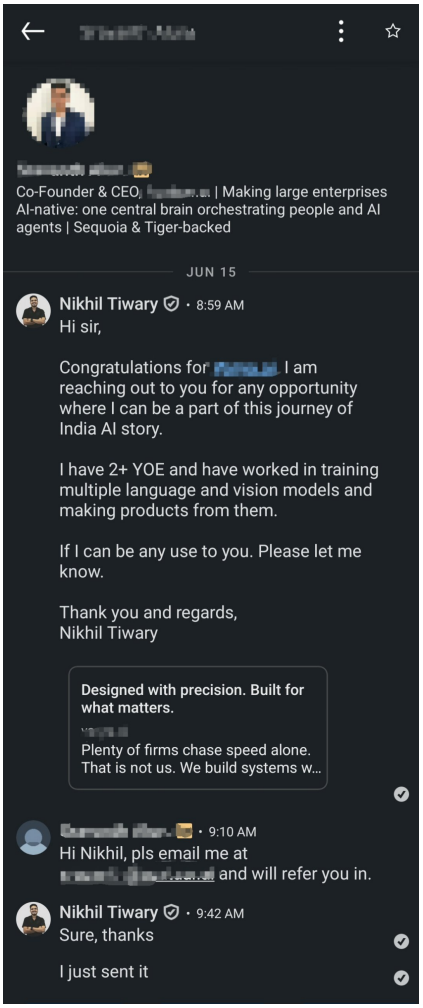
- Name and company spelled right
- First line is personal, not copy-paste
- One project with a working link
- One clear ask (chat, referral or call)
- Under 80 words
- No grammar mistakes (read it once out loud)

Where to find founders

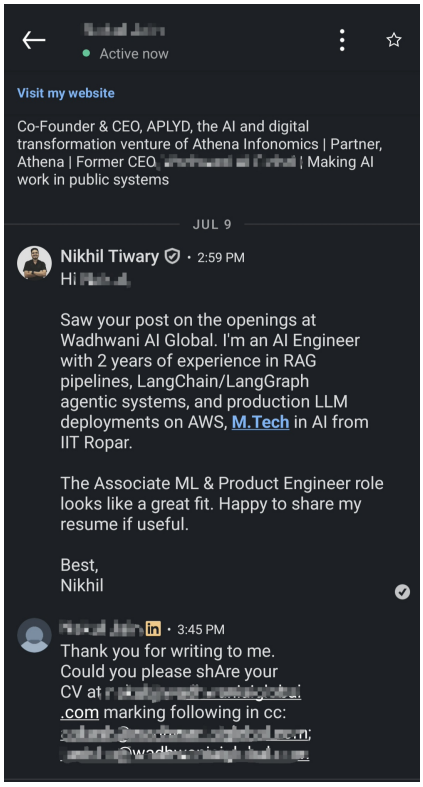
- LinkedIn search: "Founder" or "Co-Founder" + "AI" + your city
- Funding news posts on LinkedIn (startups that just raised are hiring)
- Startup job boards and founder posts saying "we're hiring"

6. Real replies

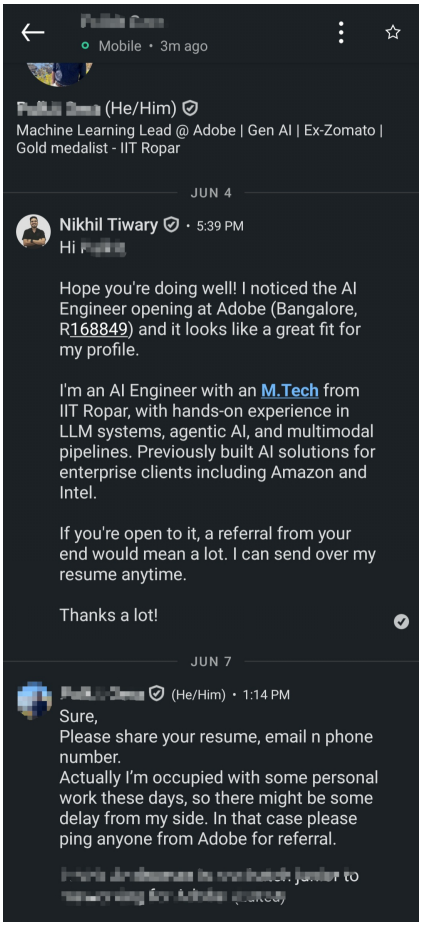
These are replies to my own DMs using these formats. Names are blurred.



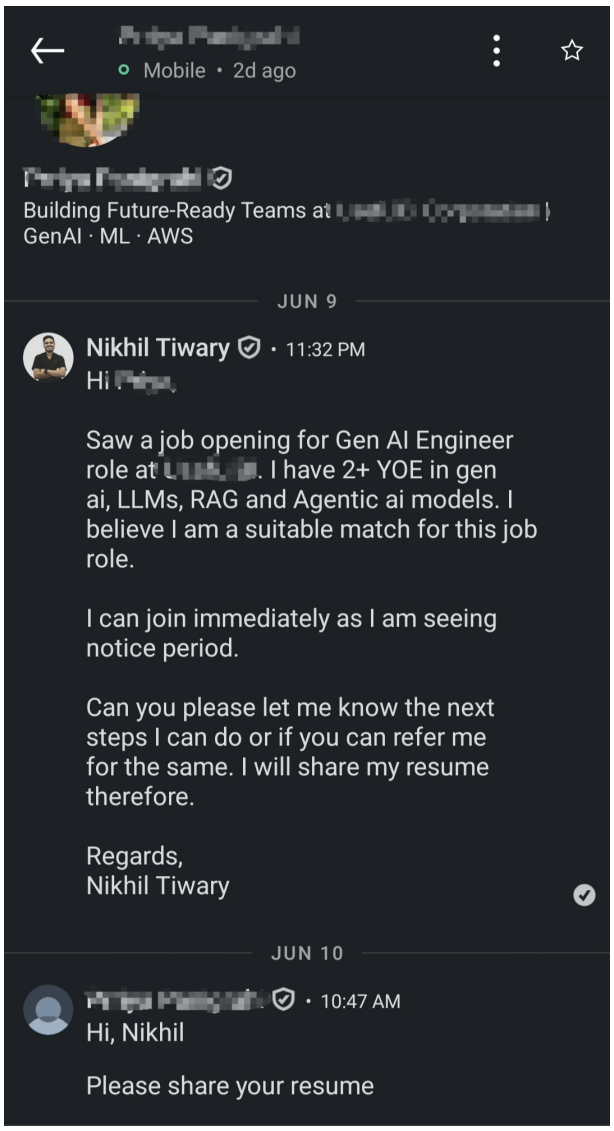
Co-Founder & CEO: "pls email me and will refer you in"



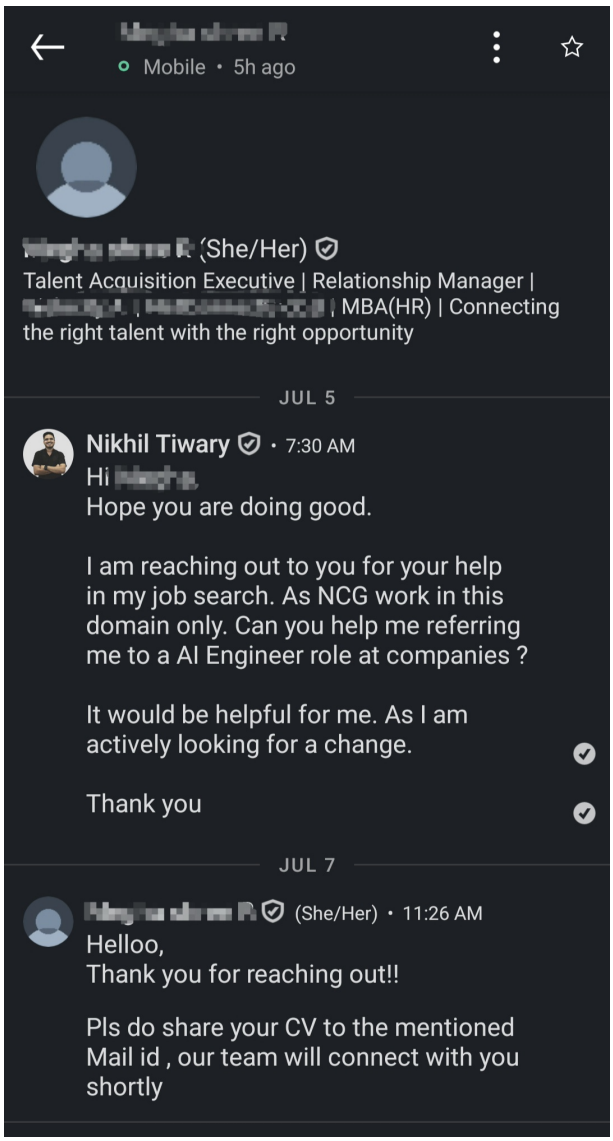
Co-Founder & CEO: asked for my CV



ML Lead: "Sure, please share your resume"



Hiring lead: "Please share your resume"



Talent acquisition: "our team will connect with you"

More real career stuff on Instagram: **@nikhiltiwary.in** | nikhiltiwary.in